



RESTORATIONESSENTIALS

Factory-Correct Restoration Reference

1979 Pontiac Trans Am Restoration Guide

Model Year 1979

Model	Pontiac Firebird Trans Am (2nd-gen F-body)
Engines	403 cid Olds V8 (185 hp); 400 cid Pontiac (180/220 hp W72)
Transmission	TH350 auto; Super T-10 4-speed (W72 mandatory)
Production	~117,108 Trans Ams — the all-time peak year
Notable	10th Anniversary Y89 (7,500); last Pontiac 400

Every specification in this guide was checked against factory literature, marque references, period road tests, and documented survivor cars. Where sources disagree or the record is silent, this guide says so rather than guessing.

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Chapter 1 — The Peak Year: Trans Am in 1979

No Firebird year outsells 1979, and no Trans Am year either: roughly 117,000 Trans Ams (sources vary between 116,535 and 117,108) out of 211,454 Firebirds — more than half the line wore the top badge. The 1979-only face (a no-grille nose with inset quad lamps and a full-width taillamp) makes it the most recognizable late second-generation car, and the engine room holds the era's neatest trick: three different V8s, two divisions, one '6.6 liter' callout. This guide restores the 1979 car with that identity question first.

Chapter 2 — What Makes 1979 Different

- **The face:** no-grille elongated nose, full-width rear lamp — 1979 only.
- **The last Pontiac 400:** engines built in 1978 and held for 1979 power the W72 cars; nothing after this year is a real Pontiac V8 in a Trans Am.
- **The Anniversary car:** 7,500 10th Anniversary Trans Ams (Y89), silver over charcoal, the first Firebird listed over \$10,000.
- **WS6 matures:** the performance package's handling specification peaks, with four-wheel discs available.

Chapter 3 — VIN and Fisher Body-Tag Decoding

The 13-character VIN reads **2** Pontiac, **W** Trans Am, **87** coupe, then the engine letter, **9** for 1979, the plant (**L** Van Nuys or **N** Norwood), and the sequence. A documented W72 example: 2W87Z9L157189 — the **Z** is the Pontiac 400. The Oldsmobile 403 cars carry their own engine letter; the decoder table in the service literature is the arbiter, and on this model year that one letter moves the car's value by multiples.

The cowl (Fisher body) tag adds build date, interior trim, and paint codes. And as with every Trans Am of the era, the Pontiac Historic Services packet is the recognized authority for W72, WS6, Y84, and Anniversary claims — buy the packet before the premium, and keep it with the car forever.



Chapter 4 — Three Engines Wearing 6.6: 403, L78 400, W72

The volume engine is the Oldsmobile 403: 185 hp, automatic only, tall 2.73 gearing — the cruiser specification most 1979 Trans Ams actually wear. The Pontiac 400 appears two ways: the L78 tune at 180 hp, and the W72 T/A 6.6 at 220 hp — a famously conservative rating; period NHRA dyno testing reported 260–280 net, a claim this guide prints as a period test report rather than a specification. The smaller 301 was offered as a credit option on the line; the 400 was not certified for California. Identity work starts with which engine the VIN promises and which one the casting numbers deliver (Chapter 15).

Why it matters: roughly 8,200 of about 117,000 cars got the Pontiac 400 in W72 form (2,485 hardtop, 2,917 T-top, 117 Special Edition, plus the Anniversary cars below). The other 109,000-odd are good cars with a different engine — restored honestly, priced accordingly.

Chapter 5 — The 10th Anniversary Trans Am

The Y89 10th Anniversary Trans Am marked a decade of the nameplate: silver and charcoal two-tone, silver leather interior, mirrored T-tops, unique dished wheels, and a \$10,620 sticker. Production: 7,500 — of which 1,817 carry the W72 Pontiac 400 with the 4-speed, and 5,683 the 403 automatic. Two Anniversary cars paced the 1979 Daytona 500. For restorers the Anniversary is a closed universe of specific parts — wheels, interior leather, graphics, T-top finish — each one documented, each one reproduced unevenly. Originality is the entire market here; the PHS packet and the car's surviving specific hardware are the restoration's foundation.

Chapter 6 — Transmissions, Axles, and the Mandatory 4-Speed

Pontiac's last word on the matter: the W72 400 came only with the Borg-Warner Super T-10 4-speed and 3.23 gearing — no automatic at any price. The 403 cars carry the TH350 automatic and economy axle ratios (2.73 typical). Any 'W72 automatic' presented for sale is two cars' worth of story, and Chapter 16 explains how to read it. Record transmission and axle codes before removal; on W72 cars the combination is identity.

Chapter 7 — WS6: Suspension, Brakes, and Steering

The WS6 Special Performance Package (1978–79) is the handling specification: quicker steering, larger sway bars, and — for 1979 — four-wheel disc brakes available within the package on Formulas and Trans Ams, the first time the line offered discs at all four corners. Car and Driver named the WS6 Trans Am its best-handling car of 1979. Restoration: the package's hardware is specific and verifiable — bars, steering box, brake components — and a genuine WS6 car is restored to the package, not to the base calibration.

Chapter 8 — Paint, the Y84 Special Edition, and the Hood Bird

The black-and-gold Special Edition continues under a new code for 1979: **Y84** (the 1977–78 cars are Y82; 1979–81 cars are Y84). The Anniversary silver/charcoal scheme is its own closed item. Everything else reads off the cowl tag. The hood bird and striping remain decals with restoration-grade placement and tone; the deep reproduction market makes correctness a research exercise, not a shopping exercise.



Chapter 9 — Production Numbers and Rarity

1979 figure	Built	Note
Trans Am (all)	117,108 (116,535 also published)	all-time model peak
Firebird (all)	211,454	best Firebird year
10th Anniversary (Y89)	7,500	1,817 W72 4-speed / 5,683 403 auto
W72 400 (non-Anniv.)	~6,500	2,485 hardtop + 2,917 T-top + 117 SE
Regular Trans Am	109,609	per period summaries

Two honest totals circulate for Trans Am production; this guide prints both rather than laundering one into certainty.

Chapter 10 — Rust-Prone Areas and Inspection Guide

The second-generation F-body rust map: rear frame rails, subframe mounts and the floors above them, floor pans, trunk floor, lower quarters, door bottoms. T-top cars add the roof system — by 1979 the larger Fisher tops — with seals, channels, and pillar bases inspected for the water history Hurst-era cars taught everyone to expect. Magnet, light, photographs, notes — before negotiation (Chapter 14).

Chapter 11 — Restoration Sequence for the 1979 Trans Am

- **1. Document** — VIN, cowl tag, engine and transmission codes, photographs; order the PHS packet immediately.
- **2. Name the car honestly** — 403, L78 400, W72, WS6, Y84, or Anniversary. Codes and the packet decide; the budget follows.
- **3. Structure first** — subframe mounts and rails before cosmetic metal.
- **4. Disassemble by system**; Anniversary- and WS6-specific hardware segregated and tagged.
- **5. Drivetrain to its documented calibration** — the three 6.6s are three different engines; restore the one you have.
- **6. Paint and graphics last**, to the cowl-tag code and package documentation.

Chapter 12 — Engine Specifications at a Glance

Item	403 (Olds)	400 L78	400 W72
Rating	185 hp	180 hp	220 hp (NHRA-period 260–280 reported)
Transmission	TH350 auto	auto / manual	Super T-10 4-speed only
Axle	2.73 typical	per build	3.23
Distinction	volume engine	base Pontiac tune	final Pontiac 400, ~8,200 cars

Chapter 13 — Options and Factory Details

- W72 T/A 6.6 — 220 hp, 4-speed and 3.23 mandatory; the collector specification.
- WS6 Special Performance Package — handling specification; 1979 four-wheel discs available.



- Y84 Special Edition — the black-and-gold package under its 1979–81 code.
- Y89 10th Anniversary — 7,500 built, \$10,620, both engines possible; the 1,817 400/4-speed cars are the summit.
- Fisher T-top roof where fitted; mirrored panels on the Anniversary car.

Chapter 14 — Buyer Inspection Checklist

- VIN engine letter matched to the engine in the car — the 403/400 question answered before price is discussed.
- PHS documentation for W72, WS6, Y84, and Anniversary claims; no packet, no premium.
- W72 cars: 4-speed present (mandatory from the factory) — an automatic 'W72' is a conversion story.
- Anniversary cars: wheels, silver leather, mirrored tops, and graphics inventoried against the closed parts list.
- Cowl tag paint/trim read against the car presented.
- T-top channels and pillars inspected with seals lifted.
- Rear rails, subframe mounts, floors, trunk mapped with photos.

Chapter 15 — Casting Numbers, Block Codes, and Date Codes

Two divisions, two casting systems: Pontiac blocks carry Pontiac casting numbers and stamped application codes; the Oldsmobile 403 carries Olds castings and its own identification. Castings precede the build and sit close to it; the stamped code must match the VIN's promise. The 1979 W72 engines were built in 1978 and held — casting dates running ahead of the car by months are expected on genuine W72 cars, which makes the PHS packet, not the casting calendar alone, the final word.

Chapter 16 — Clones and Conversions: Tells That Matter

The premium tells cluster around identity: a 403 car rebadged as a W72 (defense: VIN letter, block code, PHS packet, and the mandatory 4-speed), an Anniversary tribute (defense: the closed parts list and packet), a Y84 clone (defense: the packet). Decals and badges are reproduced perfectly; paperwork is not. An honestly described 403 Trans Am is the car most buyers actually want to drive; it only becomes a problem when it is sold as something rarer.

Chapter 17 — Critical Fasteners: Sequence and Sources

No torque value is printed that cannot be traced to factory service literature. The discipline stands: clean chased threads, lubrication as the manual specifies, the printed pattern in at least three steps, re-checks after the first heat cycle where called for — and factory values for subframe and suspension hardware, which on an F-body are structure. Values come from the 1979 Pontiac service manual in Sources; record what you used.



Recommended for this restoration

Shop exact-fit supplies on Amazon

- 1979 Pontiac Firebird factory service manual
- Pontiac 400 V8 engine rebuild kit
- 1970-1981 Firebird Trans Am restoration parts
- 1979 Pontiac Firebird parts catalog

As an Amazon Associate, RestorationEssentials earns from qualifying purchases made through these links.

Sources Consulted

Every specification in this guide was checked against published references before printing. Where sources disagree, this guide says so in the text rather than picking a number silently. The references below are the backbone of the technical chapters:

- **Pontiac factory literature.** the 1979 Pontiac service manual and dealer ordering information — authority for torque values, specifications, and option definitions
- **Pontiac Historic Services.** the recognized documentation authority for W72, WS6, Y84, and Y89 verification
- **Publications International model histories.** 1979 Firebird line history, production totals, and equipment summaries
- **GM Authority and marque technical references.** 1979 engine-availability and W72 production breakdowns
- **Period magazine testing.** Car and Driver's WS6 handling assessment and NHRA-period dyno reports, cited as period reporting

A note on numbers. Factory literature, period road tests, and marque historians do not always agree — production totals, horsepower ratings, and paint codes all have documented conflicts. This guide uses the best-supported figure in each case and flags the conflict where one exists, so you can judge for yourself.



Thank You

Thank you for choosing this RestorationEssentials guide. Whether this is your first 1979 Pontiac Trans Am or your fiftieth, you picked one of the great ones, and the fact that you are doing your homework before you turn a wrench puts you ahead of most of the field.

These cars survived because people like you refused to let them disappear. Every correct fastener, every properly decoded tag, every hour spent getting the details right keeps the history honest for the next owner and the next generation of enthusiasts.

The peak year — the last real Pontiac V8, the Anniversary car, and 117,000 buyers who knew exactly what they wanted. Restore yours as the car the codes say it is.

If this guide helped your build, we would love to hear about it. Good luck with the restoration, and enjoy every mile.

— The RestorationEssentials Team